

INNOVATION REQUIRES MORE THAN JUST A BUNCH OF IDEAS. IT NEEDS DISCIPLINE. IT NEEDS A PROCESS TO FOLLOW!



Most people thought that ideas to reality are a simple three-stage activity:

1. Develop MVP
2. Try the product
3. Launch it

However, this is an oversimplified process that is meant to be used only for easy conversations. In reality, much work needs to be done behind it.

The first and crucial step

Every idea must begin with a problem to solve or fix. In fact, it will be much better if you are thinking about transforming the problem instead of just solving it. This is the first and the most crucial step.

Crucial because you may have seen hundreds of companies floating around with their (so-called) solution in their hands, trying to find new problems to solve. It is not only a waste of time it also can limit the long-term sustainability of that business.

How many startups or businesses you can recall that existed five years ago that had innovative ideas. Most of them would be gone by now, simply because they could not find product-market fit.

On the contrary to finding product-market fit, we must look at it as market-product fit and develop what market or customer needs or wants. A few handfuls of projects that I worked on at Knewron followed this philosophy and were successful too.

Of course, finding the right problem to solve needs an empathetic approach towards your customers. If you cannot see, feel, or understand their problem, you are least likely to solve it correctly. This also means that someone else will do it someday and put you out of business if you do not do it.

Moreover, producing better ideas does not happen in silos. You need deeper insights. Developing insights is not easy, particularly when you do not know much about the industry, that domain, or the process where problems occur.

So, to begin with, you need genuine curiosity and empathy to identify what is required. Why the problem exists in the first place, and what is the root cause behind it.

Be curious and empathetic. Find out the root cause of the problem you want to solve.

Time to get creative

Once you find the problem and its root cause, you can think about many ways to solve it. For doing that effectively, you will need to generate multiple ideas. This is the second step in the innovation process.

The idea generation becomes easier if you know why that problem exists in the first place. Because whenever you fix the root cause, problems disappear. Eliminating the root cause is the best way to solve any problem.

Generate as many ideas as possible before you begin to judge them.

Here is a catch, though. To produce enough meaningful and clever ideas, you need creativity. But additionally, you also need experience. Without enough experience you cannot produce enough innovative ideas.

However, there is an antidote. It is to collaborate with other experts in various relevant domains and combine their knowledge with your creativity. When time is of essence, this is the best way to move forward.

Another way to circumvent the limitation of experience is experimentation. Many people mistake experimentation with trial and error. It is not so. Experimentation is an art. And it is also science. Experimentation teaches you so many things in a brief period that otherwise will take several years to learn.

Based on your experimental findings, and observations, etc you can generate as many ideas as possible. But do not judge them at this stage yet.

Get analytical

We all can agree that every idea is not and cannot be equally good. Some ideas are outright pointless. Some ideas are good but may not be feasible or viable from a business standpoint. Sometimes, an idea is good but the timing is not right for it.

So, the third step is to apply